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QLV 2026 · BUILDING SYSTEMS THAT OUTLIVE YOU

How the sprint works

A worked example, from the task card to the presentation

On Saturday your team will get a real workplace problem and build a plan that has to work without the people who wrote it. This guide walks through one practice case, **Harlow & Pike**, exactly as a team would work it on the day.

It shows every sheet you will use, what goes on it and when. Nothing here is the task you will get on Saturday. Your task stays sealed until the sprint opens.

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BEFORE YOU START

What is on your table

Everything you need is there when you sit down

ITEM	WHAT IT IS FOR	WHEN
Task card, 2 copies	Your problem and the facts you must work within. One stays with you, one travels with your plan	10:50
A2 board	Where the whole team builds the plan together, and what you present from	11:00 and 1:30pm
Thick markers	Drawing the five boxes and writing anything the room must read	11:00
Sticky notes, two colours	Ideas you can move around. The second colour is for questions on the plan you critique	11:00 and 11:45
Plan sheet, 2 sets	The clean written plan another team receives. One set for drafting, one for handover	11:25
Envelope	Carries your plan sheet and task card to the next table	11:40
Critique sheet	Your review of the plan you receive	11:45
Response sheet	Your answer to the critique of your own plan	12:20
Pens and highlighter	Writing on the sheets and marking the task card	All day
Masking tape	Putting your board on the wall to present	1:30pm

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SATURDAY 7 NOVEMBER

The day at a glance

10:50am	**Read.** Task cards go out to every table at the same moment. Read together and agree the real problem.
11:00am	**Build.** Draw five boxes on the A2 board. Every idea goes on a sticky note. Move notes until the team agrees.
11:25am	**Write.** One writer copies the agreed plan onto the plan sheet.
11:40am	**Hand over.** Pens down. Your plan goes to the next table in the envelope.
11:45am	**Critique.** 35 minutes to review the plan you receive.
12:20pm	**Respond.** 15 minutes to answer the critique of your plan and update your board.
12:35pm	**Lunch.**
1:30pm	**Present.** 3 to 5 minutes from your board to the judges.

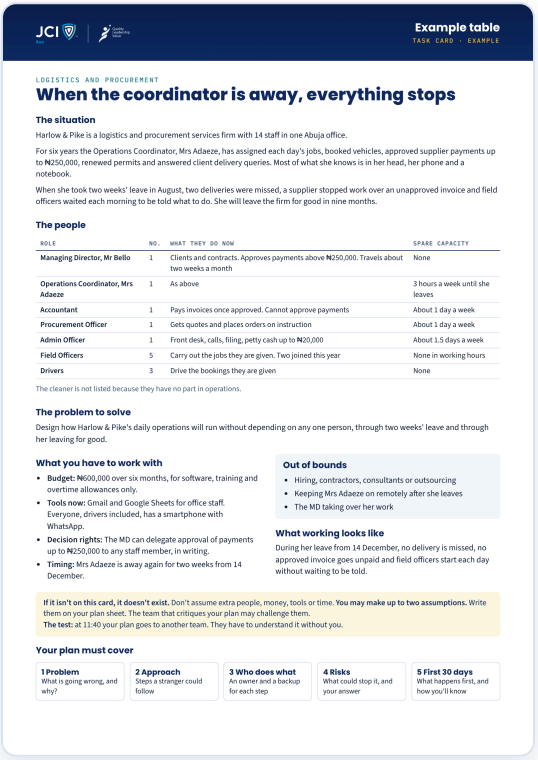
The test for everything: would this plan work without the people who wrote it?

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STEP 1 · 10:50AM

Read the task card

Ten minutes. Read it together, out loud if it helps



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Example table

TASK CARD · EXAMPLE

LOGISTICS AND PROCUREMENT

When the coordinator is away, everything stops

The situation

Harlow & Pike is a logistics and procurement services firm with 14 staff in one Abuja office.

For six years the Operations Coordinator, Mrs Adaeze, has assigned each day's jobs, booked vehicles, approved supplier payments up to ₦250,000, renewed permits and answered client delivery queries. Most of what she knows is in her head, her phone and a notebook.

When she took two weeks' leave in August, two deliveries were missed, a supplier stopped work over an unapproved invoice and field officers waited each morning to be told what to do. She will leave the firm for good in nine months.

The people

ROLE	NO.	WHAT THEY DO NOW	SPARE CAPACITY
Managing Director, Mr Bello	1	Clients and contracts. Approves payments above ₦250,000. Travels about two weeks a month	None
Operations Coordinator, Mrs Adaeze	1	As above	3 hours a week until she leaves
Accountant	1	Pays invoices once approved. Cannot approve payments	About 1 day a week
Procurement Officer	1	Gets quotes and places orders on instruction	About 1 day a week
Admin Officer	1	Front desk, calls, filing, petty cash up to ₦20,000	About 1.5 days a week
Field Officers	5	Carry out the jobs they are given. Two joined this year	None in working hours
Drivers	3	Drive the bookings they are given	None

The cleaner is not listed because they have no part in operations.

The problem to solve

Design how Harlow & Pike's daily operations will run without depending on any one person, through two weeks' leave and through her leaving for good.

What you have to work with

- **Budget:** ₦600,000 over six months, for software, training and overtime allowances only.
- **Tools now:** Gmail and Google Sheets for office staff. Everyone, drivers included, has a smartphone with WhatsApp.
- **Decision rights:** The MD can delegate approval of payments up to ₦250,000 to any staff member, in writing.
- **Timing:** Mrs Adaeze is away again for two weeks from 14 December.

Out of bounds

- Hiring, contractors, consultants or outsourcing
- Keeping Mrs Adaeze on remotely after she leaves
- The MD taking over her work

What working looks like

During her leave from 14 December, no delivery is missed, no approved invoice goes unpaid and field officers start each day without waiting to be told.

If it isn't on this card, it doesn't exist. Don't assume extra people, money, tools or time. **You may make up to two assumptions.** Write them on your plan sheet. The team that critiques your plan may challenge them.
The test: at 11:40 your plan goes to another team. They have to understand it without you.

Your plan must cover

1 Problem	2 Approach	3 Who does what	4 Risks	5 First 30 days
What is going wrong, and why?	Steps a stranger could follow	An owner and a backup for each step	What could stop it, and your answer	What happens first, and how you'll know

How to read it

- **The facts are fixed.** The people, budget, tools and dates are all you have. If it isn't on the card, it doesn't exist.
- **The approach is yours.** Nothing on the card tells you how to solve it.
- **Out of bounds** lists the shortcuts that would dodge the problem, like hiring someone new.
- **What working looks like** is the test your plan must pass.
- **Up to two assumptions.** If you must assume something, write it on your plan sheet. The other team may challenge it.

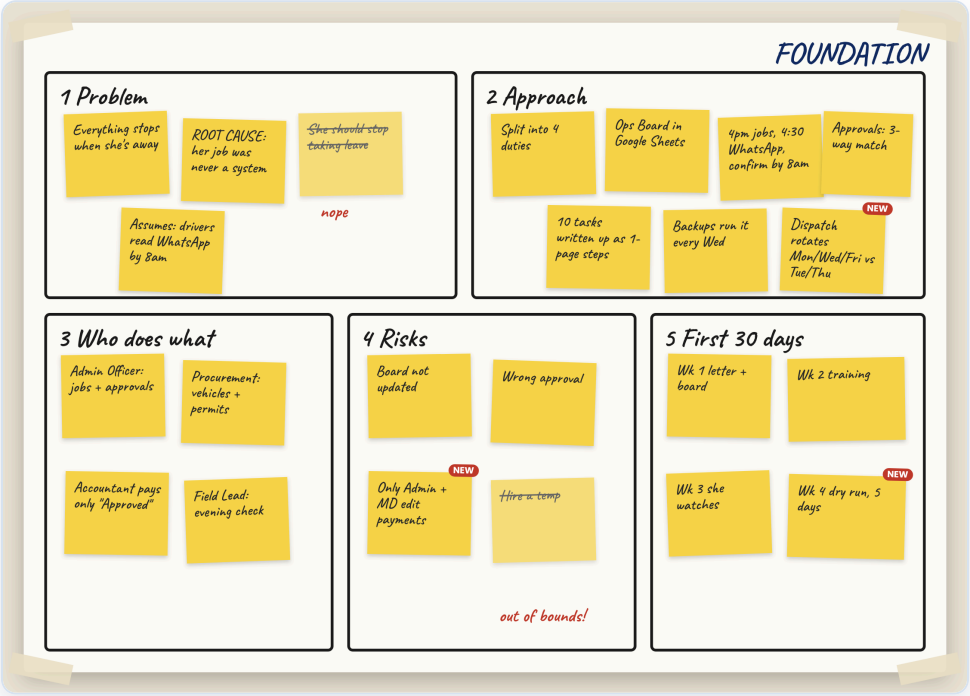
Highlight the single person or thing everything depends on. In Harlow & Pike, it is Mrs Adaeze.

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STEP 2 · 11:00AM

Build on the A2 board

The whole team works on the board, not in one person's notebook



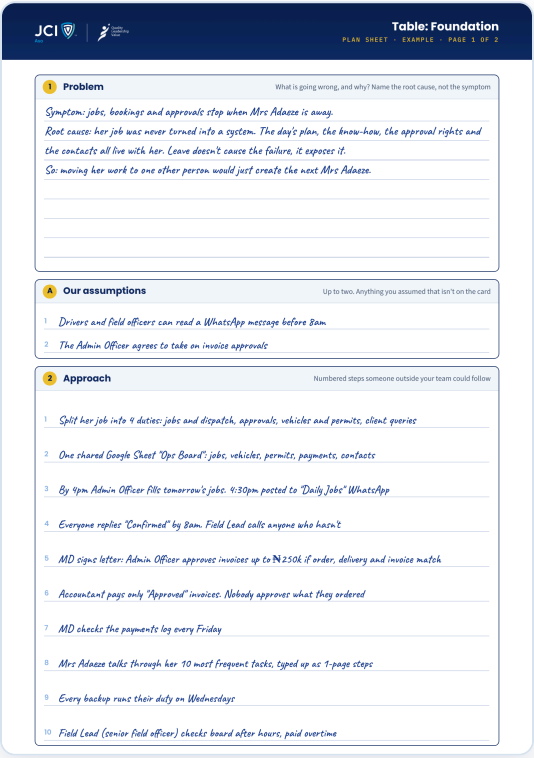
- Draw the five boxes in marker: Problem, Approach, Who does what, Risks, First 30 days.
- One idea per sticky note. Put it in a box. Move it, group it or cross it out.
- Cross out what the card rules out. Above, "Hire a temp" is out of bounds.
- Notes marked **new** were added after the critique. Your board keeps growing until you present.

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STEP 3 · 11:25AM

Write the plan sheet: page 1

One writer copies the agreed plan from the board



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Table: Foundation

PLAN SHEET · EXAMPLE · PAGE 1 OF 2

1 Problem — What is going wrong, and why? Name the root cause, not the symptom

Symptom: jobs, bookings and approvals stop when Mrs Adaeze is away.

Root cause: her job was never turned into a system. The day's plan, the know-how, the approval rights and the contacts all live with her. Leave doesn't cause the failure, it exposes it.

So: moving her work to one other person would just create the next Mrs Adaeze.

A Our assumptions — Up to two. Anything you assumed that isn't on the card

1. *Drivers and field officers can read a WhatsApp message before 8am*
2. *The Admin Officer agrees to take on invoice approvals*

2 Approach — Numbered steps someone outside your team could follow

1. *Split her job into 4 duties: jobs and dispatch, approvals, vehicles and permits, client queries*
2. *One shared Google Sheet "Ops Board": jobs, vehicles, permits, payments, contacts*
3. *By 4pm Admin Officer fills tomorrow's jobs. 4:30pm posted to "Daily Jobs" WhatsApp*
4. *Everyone replies "Confirmed" by 8am. Field Lead calls anyone who hasn't*
5. *MD signs letter: Admin Officer approves invoices up to ₦250k if order, delivery and invoice match*
6. *Accountant pays only "Approved" invoices. Nobody approves what they ordered*
7. *MD checks the payments log every Friday*
8. *Mrs Adaeze talks through her 10 most frequent tasks, typed up as 1-page steps*
9. *Every backup runs their duty on Wednesdays*
10. *Field Lead (senior field officer) checks board after hours, paid overtime*

What makes this strong

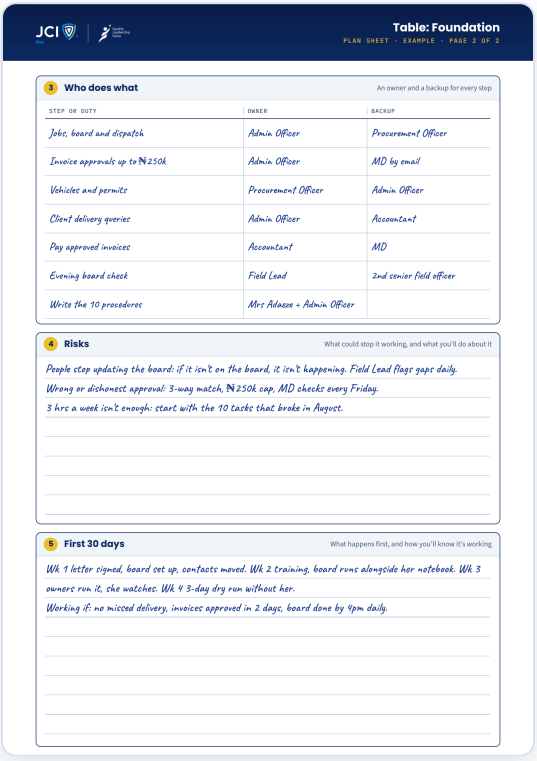
- **Problem** names the root cause, not just “she was on leave”.
- **Assumptions** are stated openly, so the other team can test them.
- **Approach** is numbered steps with times and names. A stranger could start tomorrow.

Write for a stranger. If a step needs you there to explain it, rewrite it.

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STEP 3 · 11:25AM

Write the plan sheet: page 2



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Table: Foundation

PLAN SHEET · EXAMPLE · PAGE 2 OF 2

3 Who does what — An owner and a backup for every step

STEP OR DUTY	OWNER	BACKUP
Jobs, board and dispatch	Admin Officer	Procurement Officer
Invoice approvals up to ₦250k	Admin Officer	MD by email
Vehicles and permits	Procurement Officer	Admin Officer
Client delivery queries	Admin Officer	Accountant
Pay approved invoices	Accountant	MD
Evening board check	Field Lead	2nd senior field officer
Write the 10 procedures	Mrs Adaeze + Admin Officer	

4 Risks — What could stop it working, and what you'll do about it

People stop updating the board: if it isn't on the board, it isn't happening. Field Lead flags gaps daily.

Wrong or dishonest approval: 3-way match, ₦250k cap, MD checks every Friday.

3 hrs a week isn't enough: start with the 10 tasks that broke in August.

5 First 30 days — What happens first, and how you'll know it's working

Wk 1 letter signed, board set up, contacts moved. Wk 2 training, board runs alongside her notebook. Wk 3 owners run it, she watches. Wk 4 3-day dry run without her.

Working if: no missed delivery, invoices approved in 2 days, board done by 4pm daily.

What makes this strong

- **Who does what** gives every duty an owner and a backup. That is what lets it outlive the team.
- **Risks** come with an answer, not just a worry.
- **First 30 days** ends in a test you can check: no missed delivery, invoices approved in two days.

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STEP 4 · 11:40AM

Hand it over

Pens down. Your plan moves on without you

- Put your **plan sheet** and one **task card** in the envelope.
- A Sprint Marshal carries it to the next table. Foundation's plan goes to Blueprint, Blueprint's to Scaffold and so on round the room.
- You receive another team's plan in the same way.
- Your A2 board stays with you.

This is the real test. The next team has only what you wrote. If they can't follow it, neither could the people at Harlow & Pike.

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STEP 5 · 11:45AM

Critique their plan: page 1

35 minutes. Here, Blueprint reviews Foundation's plan



Critique by Blueprint

CRITIQUE SHEET · OF THE PLAN FROM FOUNDATION · PAGE 1 OF 2

You are reviewing a plan written by another team. For each section, name one **gap**, one **question** and one **strength**. Be specific: point to the line.

1 Problem

GAP	*Doesn't say which of the four things broke first in August.*
QUESTION	*Was the stopped supplier caused by a missing approval or a missing payment?*
STRENGTH	*Clear root cause. Goes beyond "she was on leave".*

2 Approach

GAP	*Step 4 assumes every driver has data before 8am. No rule if not.*
QUESTION	*Who posts tomorrow's jobs on days the Admin Officer is off?*
STRENGTH	*The daily rhythm has real times. Easy to follow.*

3 Who does what

GAP	*Admin Officer now owns 3 duties. Isn't she the new Mrs Adaeze?*
QUESTION	*Has the Admin Officer agreed to approve invoices?*
STRENGTH	*Every duty has a named backup.*

How to critique well

- For each section, one **gap**, one **question** and one **strength**.
- Point to the line. "Step 4 assumes every driver has data" beats "the approach is weak".
- Look for the new single point of failure. Here, Blueprint spots that the Admin Officer now holds three duties.
- Use your second colour of sticky note for questions you stick on their plan.

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STEP 5 · 11:45AM

Critique their plan: page 2



Critique by Blueprint

CRITIQUE SHEET · OF THE PLAN FROM FOUNDATION · PAGE 2 OF 2

4 Risks

GAP — *No risk listed for the Ops Board itself, e.g. someone deleting rows.*

QUESTION — *Who is allowed to edit the payments log?*

STRENGTH — *The three-way match is a smart fraud check.*

5 First 30 days

GAP — *Dry run is 3 days but her leave is 14 days.*

QUESTION — *What happens if the dry run fails in week 4?*

STRENGTH — *Measures are specific and checkable.*

A Their assumptions

FAIR? — *No. 1 is fair. No. 2 is a big one: the whole approvals step depends on it.*

CHALLENGE — *If the Admin Officer says no, what happens?*

★ The one change that would make this plan strongest

Share the Admin Officer's load so no one person holds both dispatch and approvals.

Finish with

- **Their assumptions.** Are they fair? Which one would break the plan if it were wrong?
- **The one change** that would make the plan strongest. Make it specific enough to act on.

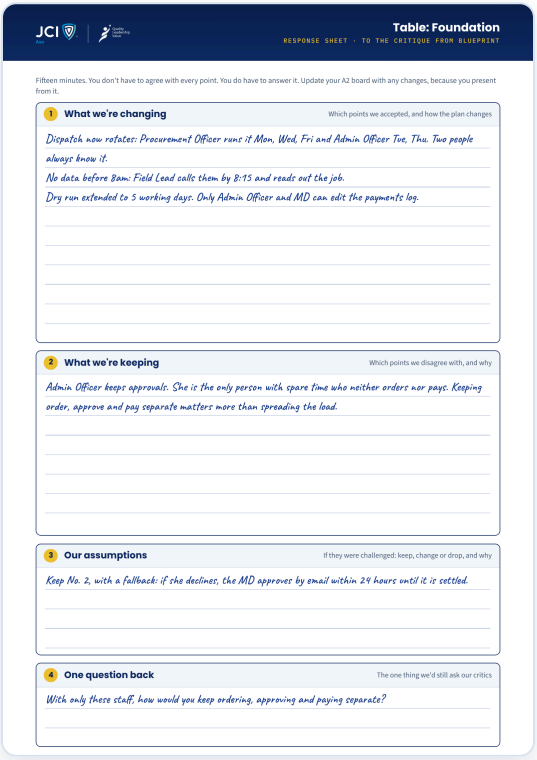
A good critique is generous and hard at the same time. Your aim is a stronger plan, not a lower score.

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STEP 6 · 12:20PM

Respond to your critique

15 minutes. Your own plan comes back with Blueprint's critique



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Table: Foundation

RESPONSE SHEET · TO THE CRITIQUE FROM BLUEPRINT

Fifteen minutes. You don't have to agree with every point. You do have to answer it. Update your A2 board with any changes, because you present from it.

1 What we're changing — Which points we accepted, and how the plan changes

Dispatch now rotates: Procurement Officer runs it Mon, Wed, Fri and Admin Officer Tue, Thu. Two people always know it.

No data before 8am: Field Lead calls them by 8:15 and reads out the job.

Dry run extended to 5 working days. Only Admin Officer and MD can edit the payments log.

2 What we're keeping — Which points we disagree with, and why

Admin Officer keeps approvals. She is the only person with spare time who neither orders nor pays. Keeping order, approve and pay separate matters more than spreading the load.

3 Our assumptions — If they were challenged: keep, change or drop, and why

Keep No. 2, with a fallback: if she declines, the MD approves by email within 24 hours until it is settled.

4 One question back — The one thing we'd still ask our critics

With only these staff, how would you keep ordering, approving and paying separate?

How to respond

- You don't have to agree with every point. You do have to answer it.
- **Changing:** Foundation rotates dispatch so two people know it, and extends the dry run.
- **Keeping:** they keep approvals with the Admin Officer and explain why.
- Update your A2 board. Those are the notes marked **new** on page 5.

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STEP 7 · 1:30PM

Present to the judges

3 to 5 minutes, from your board on the wall

A simple shape that works

30 sec	The problem and its root cause
2 min	Walk the board: approach and who does what
1 min	What you changed after the critique, and why
30 sec	Why it would work without you

What the judges score

CRITERION	IN PLAIN WORDS
Problem understood	Did you find the real cause?
A plan someone else could run	Could a stranger start tomorrow?
Outlives the team	Owners, backups, written down. This one breaks ties
Used the critique	Is the plan stronger for it?
Delivered clearly	Clear, within 5 minutes, easy to repeat back

See you on Saturday. Bring yourself and your best thinking. Everything else is on the table.